

Panama



Long dominated by the US, which recently handed over control of the canal for the first time.

1513 Vasco Núñez de Balboa sights the Pacific from Panama, which, due to its position between the two oceans, becomes a commercial center of geopolitical importance until the end of the 18th century.

1717 As a province of Colombia, Panama is transferred from the Viceroyalty of Peru to the Viceroyalty of Granada.

1821 On independence from Spain, Panama becomes part of Gran Colombia.

1830 On the breakup of Gran Colombia, Panama remains part of Colombia.

1889 French attempt to build canal ends in failure with 22,000 workers dead.

1903 With US support Panama revolts against Colombia, declaring independence. It immediately grants the US rights over an Atlantic–Pacific corridor through its territory so that a canal can be built between the Caribbean and Pacific Ocean.

1914 The Panama Canal is completed and formally opens on August 15.

1968 Accession of Brigadier-General Omar Torrijos Herrera to power in a coup.

1977 Torrijos and US President Carter sign new Panama Canal treaties transferring control of the canal to Panama on December 31, 1999.

1979 Treaties officially ending US control over the Panama Canal Zone enter into force.

1987 A state of emergency is imposed after antigovernment protests over the alleged rigging of the 1984 elections by the power behind the civilian government, General Manuel Noriega.

1989 Three days after presidential elections, Noriega annuls the results.

1989 Noriega formally assumes power as head of state with wide powers.

1989 The US installs the apparent victor in the 1989 election, Guillermo Endara, as head of state and invades with 23,000 troops to depose Noriega, whom it accuses of drug activities.

1990 Noriega surrenders to the US authorities and is taken as a prisoner to the US for trial on drug charges.

1990 The National Guard and defense forces are disbanded and replaced by the 11,800-strong Panamanian Public Force, comprising the National Police, the National Air Service, and the National Maritime Service.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE PANAMA CANAL, 1914

The Panama Canal opened on August 15, 1914. Using an ingenious system of locks to carry ships up over the isthmus, the canal dramatically affected shipping, shortening the sea journey between America's east and west coasts and obviating the need for a perilous rounding of Cape Horn at the tip of South America. The canal resulted in a massive increase in international trade and improved the fortunes of Panama. In 1999, full control of the canal (and its revenues) reverted to Panama.



1994 The Democratic Revolutionary Party (PRD), Noriega's old party but now largely pro-US, wins presidential and legislative elections.

1999 All remaining US troops leave the country when the Canal Zone is finally handed back to Panama.

1999 Spill-over from the Colombian civil war leads to increasing number of border incidents in the south of the country.

1999 Mireya Moscoso of the Arnulfista Party (PA) is elected first woman president. Lacking a legislative majority, she struggles to meet her promises to help the poor.

2004 Martin Torrijos of the PRD wins the presidency after campaigning to fight corruption and unemployment while improving the social security system.

2005 Torrijos begins social security reforms by raising pension contributions and increasing the retirement age; popular protests break out.

2006 Proposals to widen the Panama Canal to take larger ships are approved in a national referendum.

2009–10 Former Panamanian president Manuel Noriega is extradited from the US to France.

2010 The candidate of the conservative opposition Alliance for Change, Ricardo Martinelli, wins presidential election. Trial of Manuel Noriega begins in Paris.

«280–81 The Slave Trade
«318–19 Latin America Liberated

Cuba



The largest island in the Caribbean, Cuba is the only communist state in the Americas.

1492 First Europeans arrive with Christopher Columbus and claim the island for Spain.

1511 Cuba is settled and colonized by Spaniards.

1762 The British occupy Havana, returning it to Spain the next year under the Treaty of Paris. Cuba prospers under a slave-labor economy with access to North American markets. A strong Spanish garrison inhibits moves to independence.

1868 End of the slave trade.

1868–78 A major rebellion against Spanish rule initiates a 10-year guerrilla war, which ends in defeat.

1895 José Martí lands along with a small band of rebel exiles to start war of independence. Martí is killed on the first day of fighting and thousands of Cubans subsequently die in Spanish concentration camps.

1898 In support of Cuban rebels, the US declares war on Spain to protect strong US financial interests in Cuba.

1899 US occupies Cuba and installs military interim government.

1901 US is granted intervention rights and military bases, including Guantánamo Bay naval base.

1902 Tomás Estrada Palma takes over as first Cuban president. US leaves Cuba, but intervenes in 1906–09 and 1919–24.

1925–33 Dictatorship of President Gerardo Machado.

1933 Years of guerrilla activity end in revolution. Fulgencio Batista takes over as military dictator.

1955 Fidel Castro exiled after two years' imprisonment for subversion.

1956–58 Castro returns to lead a guerrilla war in the Sierra Maestra.

1959 Batista flees. Castro takes over with his brother Raúl, Che Guevara, and Camilo Cienfuegos as his deputies. Wholesale nationalizations; Cuba reorganized on Soviet model.

1961 US breaks off relations. US-backed invasion of Bay of Pigs by anti-Castro Cubans fails. Cuba declares itself a Marxist-Leninist state.

1962 US economic and political blockade. Missile crisis: Soviet deployment of nuclear weapons in Cuba leads to extreme Soviet–US tension; war averted by Khrushchev ordering withdrawal of the weapons.

1965 Che Guevara resigns to pursue foreign liberation wars.

1972 Cuba joins COMECON (the communist economic bloc).

1976 New socialist constitution. Cuban troops fight in Angola until 1991.

1977 Sends troops to fight in Ethiopia.

1980 About 25,000 Cubans, including many “undesirables” (criminals and others), are permitted to leave for the US.

1982 US tightens sanctions and bans flights and tourism to Cuba.

1991 As USSR collapses, Cuba loses valuable trading partner; rationing is tightened as economy weakens. Policy of encouraging tourism to save economy.

2002 US base at Guantánamo Bay used as US prison in “war on terror.”

2006 After an illness and surgery, Castro transfers power to his brother Raúl.

2008 Castro announces he will step down as president. His brother, Raúl takes over and a slow process of liberalization begins. The EU formally lifts sanctions against the country. In September, Cuba is devastated by Hurricanes Gustav and Ike, leaving 200,000 homeless.

«280–81 The Slave Trade
«422–23 Viva la Revolución

CUBAN DICTATOR (1926–)

FIDEL CASTRO

Revolutionary leader of Cuba since 1959, Fidel Castro was a lawyer from a wealthy family who took up arms against the Batista regime. Attacked by many for the lack of democracy and human rights in Cuba, Castro's policies have nevertheless given Cubans one of the highest life expectancies in Latin America and a high literacy rate. Despite this, thousands have risked their lives to flee Cuba in search of a better life in the US.

